

A PLACID SURFACE
Early morning mist lifts from the Siliserh Lake in Sariska

of DJs blaring bhajans fades away as the gate swings shut. Instead, peafowl call to each other and water splashes from a fountain. A horse whickers softly behind a bamboo thicket. We step onto a tree-shaded pavilion with gleaming flagstones. A white-clad attendant comes forward with cool scented towels and glasses of tart lemonade. Welcome to luxury resort land.

Having checked out the website, we know what to expect: palatial rooms and private pools to lounge around in; personal butlers and spa therapies to pamper us; "curated" meals and "experiences" to make every moment Insta-worthy and memorable. All for a hefty price tag. But even the jaded palate can't help but be refreshed by the Lodge's tangled greenery, its youthful staff and the thoughtful care that has gone into its making.

Sariska Lodge has been started by Anand and Rie Shekhawat who spent years working for Aman Resorts before opening their own place. Anand's father was a forest officer, and he grew up in wild places all over Rajasthan. Settling down outside Sariska enabled him to marry his love for the jungle with his vocation in the hospitality industry. Eleven stone-built suites are dotted about amidst dense groves of grasses, trees and flowering shrubs. Winding paths connect them to the dining room, spa, pool and stables. The rooms are a cool haven from the muggy monsoon heat, their elegance lightened by whimsical tiger and leopard motifs on the blinds, bedside lamps, cushions and pictures.

Big cats are, indeed, the chief reason why people visit Sariska. But while the Tiger Reserve is closed during the rains, I soon discover that there is plenty to see and do in the surrounding countryside. We drive out in the late afternoon to Mangalsar lake, passing below the picturesque Tehla fort perched on a hilltop above. A herd of camels browses through the babul trees, the bells around their necks tinkling desultorily. I can't help but exclaim

THE INFORMATION

GETTING THERE

Sariska National Park is a 3-hr drive from Delhi (218 km) and 2hr 25min from Jaipur (107km)

LOCATION

Sariska Lodge is next to the park's Tehla Gate, 50km from Alwar

ACCOMMODATION

11 private suites, ranging from Fort Suites to Mountain Suites, Pool Suites and the Family Pool Suite

TARIFF

From ₹ 20,700 plus taxes for two, including breakfast and wi-fi

WHAT TO DO

Experiences at Sariska Lodge include private dinners with live folk music, barbecue grill bush dinner, breakfast at the fort ruins. Further afield, morning and evening safaris to Sariska Tiger Reserve; boulder trail safaris to track leopards

CONTACT DETAILS

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